

FIVE QUESTIONS TO FILTER AGENTS

Once you understand these categories, choosing becomes easier. Do not ask, "Which AI agent is best?" Ask, "What job am I hiring this agent to do?" Use this five-question filter before choosing any agent.

Question 1: What is the main task?

Is it research, writing, coding, email, reporting, customer support, scheduling, data analysis or automation?

Question 2: What data will the agent need?

Will it need PDFs, emails, spreadsheets, CRM data, meeting transcripts, webpages, code files, images or personal notes?

Question 3: What action should it be allowed to take?

Should it only summarise? Should it draft? Should

it edit files? Should it update records? Should it send messages?

Question 4: What must require human approval?

Sending emails, publishing posts, deleting files, booking tickets, approving payments and sharing confidential information should always require approval.

Question 5: What happens if it makes a mistake?

This is the most important question. If the consequence is small, such as a poor first draft, you can experiment freely. If the consequence is serious, such as sending client data, changing records, booking tickets or making payments, keep the agent on a very short leash.

or Notion every day, the right agent may be the one that reduces context switching.

Instead of copying an email into a chatbot, asking for a reply, copying the reply back, and then editing it, an integrated agent can work closer to where the task lives. The same applies to meetings. A meeting agent that creates summaries, action items and follow-up emails is more practical than a chatbot that merely explains how to write minutes.

Begin with read-only access

Integration should not mean blind trust. Start with read-only tasks. Let the agent summarise unread emails, but not send replies. Let it draft calendar plans, but not move meetings. Let it classify invoices, but not approve payments. Let it prepare a customer support answer, but not close the ticket automatically.

In the first month, your goal is to observe how the agent behaves. Does it understand your tone? Does it miss details? Does it invent facts? Does it follow constraints? Treat the first month as probation.

Why language support matters in India

For Indian users, language support deserves separate attention. Many readers will not work only in English. Emails may be in English, WhatsApp messages in Hinglish, customer comments in Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Bengali, Marathi, Kannada or Malayalam, and official documents in formal English.

The best agent for you is not merely the one with the strongest benchmark score. It is the one that handles your

actual language mix. Test this before committing. Give the agent a sample customer complaint in Hinglish. Ask it to reply in polite Hindi. Give it a Marathi notice and ask for an English summary. Give it a technical paragraph and ask for a simple explanation in classroom-friendly language. The result will tell you more than any marketing page.

The cost reality check

Cost is another real-world filter. Many agent features sit behind paid plans. Some charge per user per month. Some charge by usage. Some need enterprise licences. Some are free but limited.

Students, freelancers and small offices should begin with low-cost workflows before buying subscriptions. A sensible approach is to maintain three tiers. Tier one is free or already included tools. Tier two is one paid general-purpose AI plan. Tier three is specialised tools only when they save measurable time or generate measurable revenue.

If a tool does not save time, improve output or reduce errors, it is entertainment, not infrastructure.

Step-by-step: Build your first agent toolkit

Step 1: List your recurring tasks

Write down ten tasks you do every week. Examples: reply to emails, prepare reports, summarise documents, create social captions, compare products, track expenses, make presentations, clean spreadsheets, plan lessons, follow up with leads.